

New Cockatoo Parent Guide



Everything you need for a happy, confident start together — from shopping lists to first-week wisdom, the Felix way.

Before Felix Arrives

The welcome-home shopping list



The essentials

- ☐ A cage at least 36" x 36" x 48" (smaller species like Goffin's) with bar spacing of 1-1.5"
- ☐ Several perches of varying diameter & texture
- ☐ Food + water dishes
- ☐ Quality pellet-based diet
- ☐ Cuttlebone or mineral block
- ☐ Sturdy chew toys — cockatoos are powerful beaks

The happy extras

- ☐ Foraging toys for mental stimulation
- ☐ A secure travel carrier
- ☐ Full-spectrum lighting if natural sunlight is limited
- ☐ Bird-safe, unscented cleaning supplies
- ☐ A cage cover for consistent sleep
- ☐ Rope perches & swings for climbing and exercise

Felix's tip

Set up the cage completely — perches, food, toys — a day or two before your bird arrives, so it's ready and settled from the very first hour.



The First Week

Slow and gentle wins every heart



DAYS
1-2

Quiet settling

Let your bird settle into the new cage with minimal handling. A partially covered cage can help them feel secure. Keep the room dim and calm in the evenings — consistent quiet hours help a stressed bird settle into a normal sleep rhythm faster.

DAYS
3-4

Soft hellos

Talk and whistle calmly nearby. Offer a treat by hand slowly — let curiosity lead rather than reaching in. Try sitting near the cage reading aloud — your voice becomes familiar background noise instead of something to startle at.

DAYS
5-7

Gentle interaction

Begin short, calm interaction or step-up training if your bird seems ready. Keep sessions brief and positive. Listen for soft beak grinding at bedtime — it's a quiet, contented sound that means they're relaxing into the new home.

WEEK
2+

Building trust

Settle into a daily routine of talking, out-of-cage time, and consistent light/dark cycles, then book a first avian vet visit. Rotate in just one new toy at a time — too many changes at once can overwhelm a bird still settling in.



Feeding Basics

Happy tummies, healthy bodies



How much & how often

- ✚✚ Pellets as the diet's base — roughly 60% of the diet
- ✚✚ Vegetables about 30% of the diet: carrots, broccoli, bell peppers, and cooked sweet potato are great staples
- ✚✚ Leafy greens like kale in moderation — go easy on spinach specifically, since it can interfere with calcium absorption
- ✚✚ Fruit & nuts round out the last 10%: apple (seeds removed), banana, blueberries, or a few unsalted nuts as a treat
- ✚✚ Seeds are a treat, not a full diet — a seed-only diet is unhealthy long-term
- ✚✚ Fresh water changed daily, from multiple sources if possible
- ✚✚ Remove uneaten fresh food within a few hours to prevent spoilage

Never feed your cockatoo

- ✚✚ Avocado — genuinely toxic to birds, unlike most pets
- ✚✚ Chocolate, caffeine & alcohol
- ✚✚ Salty or sugary human snacks
- ✚✚ Onion & garlic in large amounts
- ✚✚ Apple seeds & fruit pits (trace cyanide compounds)

If something risky gets eaten

Call your vet or the ASPCA Animal Poison Control Center right away:

(888) 426-4435 — available 24/7



A Cockatoo-Safe Home

Curiosity-proofing 101



Plants to keep far away

- ✂✂ Avocado plants (the whole plant, not just the fruit)
- ✂✂ Oleander, azalea & lily of the valley
- ✂✂ Philodendron & dieffenbachia

Safe greenery instead

- ✂✂ Spider plant
- ✂✂ Areca palm
- ✂✂ Bamboo palm
- ✂✂ Parlor palm
- ✂✂ Calathea (prayer plant)

Around the house

- ✂✂ Never use non-stick (Teflon/PTFE) cookware near your bird — overheated fumes are fatal within minutes
- ✂✂ Avoid aerosols, scented candles & air fresheners — birds have extremely sensitive respiratory systems
- ✂✂ Keep ceiling fans off during out-of-cage time
- ✂✂ Cover or drain open water (toilets, sinks) during floor/room time
- ✂✂ Cage location away from kitchen fumes, drafts & direct scorching sun
- ✂✂ Strong cage locks matter — cockatoos are famous escape artists with the beak strength to work a latch open



Cleaning & Care

A simple rhythm keeps everyone healthy



Every day

- ✚✚ Wash food & water dishes, refill with fresh water
- ✚✚ Change cage liner or paper

Every week

- ✚✚ Wipe down perches, bars, and toys with a bird-safe (unscented) cleaner
- ✚✚ Deep-clean the cage tray
- ✚✚ Rotate or clean toys to keep things interesting and hygienic

Good to know

- ✚✚ Bathing or misting 2-3 times a week supports healthy feathers for most species
- ✚✚ Never use harsh chemical cleaners near a bird — their respiratory systems are extremely sensitive
- ✚✚ Full cage disinfect (bars, corners, hidden spots): monthly



Health & Vet Care

A little routine goes a long way



The usual schedule

- ✚ First avian vet visit within the first week or two of coming home
- ✚ Annual wellness visits, since birds hide illness very well
- ✚ Ask about safe wing, nail & beak maintenance for your specific species

Call the vet if you notice

- ♥ Tail bobbing with each breath, or open-mouth breathing
- ♥ Fluffed feathers for an extended time, or sitting low in the cage
- ♥ Discharge from the eyes or nares, or a drooping wing
- ♥ Not eating, or droppings looking very different than usual
- ♥ Feather plucking or self-mutilation — often a sign of stress, boredom, or unmet social needs

My cockatoo's vet info

Clinic: _____

Phone: _____

Emergency clinic: _____

Phone: _____



Cool Cockatoo Facts

A little trivia to impress your friends



1

Birds don't have vocal cords — they make sound with a unique organ called the syrinx, which lets some species mimic speech with remarkable precision.

2

Cockatoos are a genuinely long-term commitment: smaller species like Goffin's commonly live around 40 years, and larger cockatoos can live 60-70+ years.

3

A bird's bones are lightweight and partially hollow, an adaptation for flight built into their entire skeleton.

4

Birds preen for a significant part of each day — it keeps feathers aligned, clean, and waterproof.

5

Cockatoos are sometimes confused with cockatiels because the names sound similar, but they're genuinely different birds — cockatiels are small parakeets, while true cockatoos like Felix are much larger parrots.

6

Cockatoos are famously affectionate 'velcro birds' — they bond deeply with their people and need real daily interaction, not just cage time.

7

Parrots are considered among the most cognitively advanced birds, capable of problem-solving and even basic tool use in some species.

8

Cockatoos are known for being escape artists — their strong, dexterous beaks can work open weak cage latches.

9

A bird's keel bone (breastbone) anchors powerful flight muscles that can make up 15-25% of their total body weight.

10

Cockatoos are among the loudest pet birds, with piercing calls especially around sunrise and sunset — a real thing to plan for before bringing one home.

